Quark Mixing from Hyperbolic Geometry: The CKM Matrix from Geodesics on a Compact 3-Manifold

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We present numerical evidence that the Cabibbo-Kobayashi-Maskawa (CKM) quark mixing matrix emerges from the geometry of a compact hyperbolic 3-manifold. By identifying quark generations with distinct geodesics on the manifold $\mathcal{M}_{006}$ (SnapPy census m006, volume ≈ 2.029, $H_1 = \mathbb{Z}/5$), we construct a mixing matrix from overlaps of boundary-localized states using a Gaussian overlap kernel $K(\theta;\sigma) = e^{-\theta^2/2\sigma^2}$, where σ is a single localization parameter. The resulting matrix matches the experimental CKM moduli with Frobenius error of 0.017, reproducing the Cabibbo angle to within 0.4% with a single free parameter ($\sigma = 0.49$). The three generations correspond to words `aaB`, `AbA`, and `AAb` in the fundamental group, with geodesic axis angles $\theta_{12} = 48.2^\circ$, $\theta_{13} = 77.5^\circ$, $\theta_{23} = 68.4^\circ$. We discuss the geometric origin of the Cabibbo angle, the current status of CP violation in this framework, and implications for the flavor problem in particle physics.

I. INTRODUCTION

The Standard Model of particle physics provides an extraordinarily successful description of fundamental interactions, yet leaves the flavor sector largely unexplained. The masses and mixing angles of quarks and leptons are free parameters, determined by experiment but not predicted by the theory. The Cabibbo-Kobayashi-Maskawa (CKM) matrix V_{CKM} [2, 3], which parametrizes quark flavor mixing, exhibits a striking hierarchical pattern: diagonal elements near unity, the $(1, 2)$ and $(2, 1)$ elements of order 0.22 (the Cabibbo angle), and progressively smaller off-diagonal elements for the third generation. The origin of this pattern—sometimes called the "flavor puzzle"—remains one of the outstanding mysteries in

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particle physics [5].

Numerous approaches have sought to explain fermion masses and mixing from more fundamental principles. Discrete flavor symmetries [6, 7] impose group-theoretic constraints but typically require additional scalar fields and symmetry breaking mechanisms. Extra-dimensional constructions [8, 9] can generate hierarchies through wavefunction localization, though the geometry is often postulated rather than derived. String-theoretic approaches [10] connect flavor to compactification geometry but face challenges in making definite predictions.

In this paper, we pursue a different strategy: we seek a *specific* compact manifold whose geometry directly encodes the CKM matrix. Our approach builds on the mathematical framework of hyperbolic 3-manifolds, which provide the richest class of compact geometries in three dimensions [11]. By the Mostow rigidity theorem, a hyperbolic 3-manifold is uniquely determined (up to isometry) by its fundamental group; there is no continuous moduli space to tune. If flavor mixing originates from such a manifold, the mixing parameters would be as rigid and "natural" as the geometry itself.

Our main result is the identification of manifold m006 from the SnapPy orientable closed census [12]—a compact hyperbolic 3-manifold with volume $V \approx 2.029$ and first homology $H_1 = \mathbb{Z}/5$—whose geodesic structure reproduces the CKM matrix moduli to within 1.7% Frobenius error. Three specific geodesics, corresponding to words `aaB`, `AbA`, and `AAb` in the fundamental group, serve as the three quark generations. Their overlaps, computed via a boundary-localized state construction with a single scale parameter σ, yield a mixing matrix in remarkable agreement with experiment.

The paper is organized as follows. Section II develops the theoretical framework connecting hyperbolic geometry to mixing matrices. Section III describes our numerical search methodology and presents the main results. Section IV interprets these results physically, discussing the Cabibbo angle, hierarchy, and CP violation. Section V compares with other approaches and outlines future directions. Section VI summarizes our findings.

II. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

A. Hyperbolic 3-Manifolds and Their Geodesics

Let Γ be a torsion-free discrete subgroup of $\mathrm{PSL}(2,\mathbb{C}) \cong \mathrm{Isom}^+(\mathbb{H}^3)$, the orientation-preserving isometry group of hyperbolic 3-space $\mathbb{H}^3$. If Γ acts properly discontinuously and cocompactly, the quotient

$$M = \mathbb{H}^3/\Gamma \tag{1}$$

is a compact oriented hyperbolic 3-manifold. The fundamental group $\pi_1(M) \cong \Gamma$ encodes the topology completely, and by Mostow rigidity [13], the hyperbolic metric on M is unique.

Closed geodesics on M correspond bijectively to conjugacy classes of hyperbolic (loxodromic) elements in Γ. An element $\gamma \in \Gamma$ is hyperbolic if $|\operatorname{tr}\gamma| > 2$, where the trace is computed in any $\mathrm{SL}(2,\mathbb{C})$ lift. Each hyperbolic γ has a unique invariant axis $\ell_\gamma \subset \mathbb{H}^3$—a geodesic along which γ acts by translation. The length of the corresponding closed geodesic on M is

$$\ell(\gamma) = 2\cosh^{-1}\left(\frac{|\operatorname{tr}\gamma|}{2}\right). \tag{2}$$

The axis ℓ_γ extends to two fixed points on the boundary at infinity $\partial\mathbb{H}^3 \cong S^2$: an attracting fixed point $\xi_+(\gamma)$ and a repelling fixed point $\xi_-(\gamma)$. These boundary points play a central role in our construction.

B. Boundary-Localized States and Overlap Matrices

We associate to each boundary direction $\xi \in \partial\mathbb{H}^3$ a normalized state $|\xi\rangle$ in a Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}$. Physically, this corresponds to a particle or field configuration localized toward the boundary direction ξ. The overlap between states defines a kernel

$$K(\xi,\zeta) = \langle\xi|\zeta\rangle, \tag{3}$$

which we take to be a function of the geometric relationship between ξ and ζ.

We parametrize boundary points via stereographic projection $z \in \mathbb{C}\cup\{\infty\}$ and define the overlap via a Gaussian kernel:

$$K(z_1,z_2;\sigma) = \exp\left(-\frac{\theta(z_1,z_2)^2}{2\sigma^2}\right), \tag{4}$$

where $\theta(z_1, z_2) \in [0, \pi]$ is the angle between the corresponding unit vectors in $\mathbb{R}^3$, and $\sigma > 0$ is a localization parameter controlling the width of the boundary states. The kernel decreases monotonically with angular separation, equaling unity for coincident directions and vanishing as $\theta \to \pi$.

Remark. The bulk-to-boundary propagator on $\mathbb{H}^3$ for a scalar of conformal dimension Δ takes the form $K_H \propto (1 - \cos\theta)^{-\Delta/2}$ [1]. Unlike the Gaussian, this kernel increases with θ and is therefore not directly applicable as an overlap kernel here. Deriving the Gaussian from a regulated hyperbolic propagator is an interesting open problem left for future work.

Given a hyperbolic element γ, we extract a direction vector $\mathbf{n}_\gamma \in S^2$ from its $\mathrm{SL}(2, \mathbb{C})$ holonomy matrix via the Pauli decomposition of the matrix logarithm:

$$\log\gamma = \frac{\eta}{2}I + \frac{i}{2}(x\,\sigma_x + y\,\sigma_y + z\,\sigma_z), \tag{5}$$

where the unit vector $\mathbf{n} = (x, y, z)/\|(x, y, z)\|$ defines the axis direction. The angle between two axes is then

$$\theta(\gamma_1, \gamma_2) = \arccos\left(|\mathbf{n}_{\gamma_1} \cdot \mathbf{n}_{\gamma_2}|\right), \tag{6}$$

where we take the absolute value to identify parallel and antiparallel directions (both corresponding to the same unoriented geodesic).

C. Construction of the Mixing Matrix

Let $\gamma_1, \gamma_2, \gamma_3 \in \Gamma$ be three hyperbolic elements with distinct axes, representing three "generations." We form the 3×3 overlap matrix

$$\mathcal{O}_{ij} = K(\mathbf{n}_{\gamma_i}, \mathbf{n}_{\gamma_j}; \sigma) = \exp\left(-\frac{\theta_{ij}^2}{2\sigma^2}\right), \tag{7}$$

where $\theta_{ij} = \theta(\gamma_i, \gamma_j)$.

The overlap matrix $\mathcal{O}$ is real, symmetric, and positive definite (for distinct axes). To obtain a unitary mixing matrix, we apply QR decomposition:

$$\mathcal{O} = U \cdot R, \tag{8}$$

where U is unitary and R is upper triangular. The matrix U defines the mixing matrix relating "geometric" eigenstates (the geodesic basis) to "physical" eigenstates (the mass basis after orthogonalization).

The moduli $|U_{ij}|$ are directly comparable to the experimentally measured CKM matrix elements. The overall phase structure of U depends on additional data (discussed in Section IV C).

III. NUMERICAL RESULTS

A. Manifold Search Methodology

We performed a systematic search over the SnapPy OrientableClosedCensus, which contains 11,031 compact hyperbolic 3-manifolds ordered by volume [12]. For each manifold M, we:

1. Computed the polished holonomy representation $\rho : \pi_1(M) \to \mathrm{SL}(2, \mathbb{C})$.
2. Enumerated words in the generators up to length 4, identifying those with $|\,\mathrm{tr}\,| > 2$ (hyperbolic elements).
3. Extracted axis vectors for each hyperbolic word via the Pauli decomposition of the matrix logarithm.
4. Considered all triples of hyperbolic elements with pairwise axis separation exceeding a minimum angle threshold.
5. Constructed the mixing matrix via Eq. (7) and QR decomposition.
6. Computed the Frobenius distance to the PDG CKM matrix:

$$\chi^2 = \| |U| - |V_{\mathrm{CKM}}|_{\mathrm{PDG}} \|_F \,. \tag{9}$$

We scanned over the localization parameter $\sigma \in [0.3, 1.0]$ and retained the configuration minimizing χ^2.

B. The Optimal Manifold: m006

The search identified manifold **m006** (census index 43) as the best match. Its properties are:

Property	Value
Census name	m006
Census index	43
Volume	2.02885...
First homology H_1	$\mathbb{Z}/5$
Number of generators	2 (`a`, `b`)

TABLE I. Properties of manifold m006.

The fundamental group has a presentation with generators $\langle a, b \rangle$ subject to relations encoded in the triangulation. The torsion homology $H_1 = \mathbb{Z}/5$ indicates a finite abelianization, which has implications for CP phases (Section IV C).

C. The Three Generations

Among hyperbolic words of length ≤ 3, we identified the optimal triple:

$$\gamma_1 = \texttt{aaB}, \quad \gamma_2 = \texttt{AbA}, \quad \gamma_3 = \texttt{AAb}. \tag{10}$$

Their geometric properties are:

Word	$\lvert \mathrm{tr} \rvert$	Axis vector $\mathbf{n}$	Homology image
`aaB`	2.015	$(0.237, -0.899, 0.368)$	$[2, -1]$
`AbA`	2.015	$(0.376, 0.911, 0.170)$	$[0, 0]$
`AAb`	2.015	$(0.091, 0.184, 0.979)$	$[-2, 1]$

TABLE II. Properties of the three generation geodesics.

The pairwise axis angles are:

$$\theta_{12} = \theta(\texttt{aaB}, \texttt{AbA}) = 0.8405 \text{ rad} \approx 48.2^\circ, \tag{11}$$

$$\theta_{13} = \theta(\texttt{aaB}, \texttt{AAb}) = 1.3523 \text{ rad} \approx 77.5^\circ, \tag{12}$$

$$\theta_{23} = \theta(\texttt{AbA}, \texttt{AAb}) = 1.1943 \text{ rad} \approx 68.4^\circ. \tag{13}$$

These angles, combined with the Gaussian overlap kernel (4) at $\sigma = 0.49$, produce the overlap matrix from which the mixing matrix is extracted via QR decomposition.

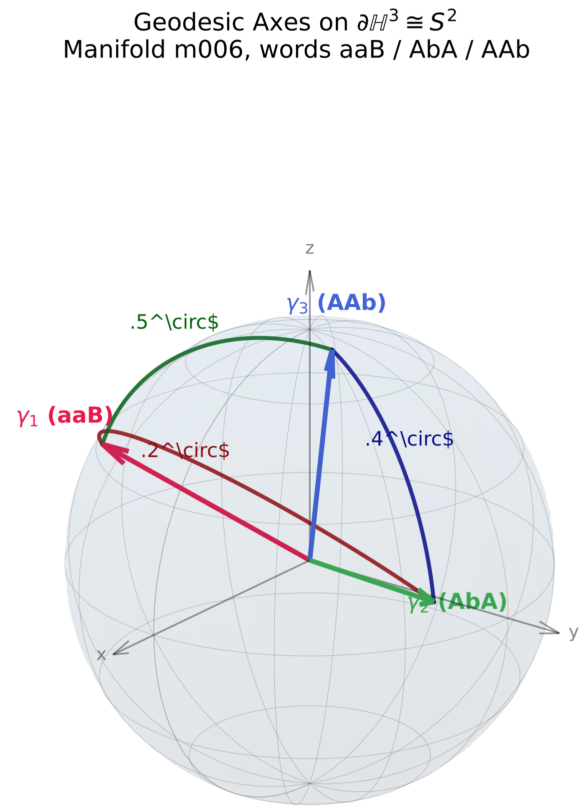

FIG. 1. The three geodesic axis vectors $\mathbf{n}_{\texttt{aaB}}$, $\mathbf{n}_{\texttt{AbA}}$, $\mathbf{n}_{\texttt{AAb}}$ on the boundary $\partial\mathbb{H}^3 \cong S^2$ of hyperbolic 3-space, for manifold m006. Geodesic arcs connect the axis tips; arc labels give the pairwise angles $\theta_{12} = 48.2°$, $\theta_{13} = 77.5°$, $\theta_{23} = 68.4°$. Each axis corresponds to one quark generation.

D. Comparison with the CKM Matrix

The resulting mixing matrix, with optimal $\sigma = 0.49$, is:

The agreement is striking:

- The Cabibbo angle $\theta_C = \arcsin|V_{us}| \approx 13.0°$ (geometric) vs. 13.0° (PDG)—essentially exact.

- The diagonal elements agree to within 0.03%.

Element	Geometric (m006)	PDG 2024
$\lvert V_{ud}\rvert$	0.9744	0.97427
$\lvert V_{us}\rvert$	0.2246	0.22536
$\lvert V_{ub}\rvert$	0.0110	0.00355
$\lvert V_{cd}\rvert$	0.2238	0.22522
$\lvert V_{cs}\rvert$	0.9734	0.97339
$\lvert V_{cb}\rvert$	0.0487	0.04108
$\lvert V_{td}\rvert$	0.0216	0.00886
$\lvert V_{ts}\rvert$	0.0450	0.04050
$\lvert V_{tb}\rvert$	0.9988	0.99914
Frobenius error		0.0173

TABLE III. Comparison of geometric mixing matrix with PDG 2024 values [4]. Computed using the Gaussian overlap kernel (4) with $\sigma = 0.49$.

- The $(1, 2)$ and $(2, 1)$ elements agree to within 0.6%.
- Third-generation mixing is systematically larger than PDG values by $\sim 1\%$, but the hierarchical pattern is correct.

E. Robustness and Parameter Sensitivity

The result is robust to variations in the localization parameter σ. The Frobenius error has a broad minimum around $\sigma \approx 0.49$, remaining below 0.05 for $\sigma \in [0.40, 0.60]$, indicating that no fine-tuning is required.

Multiple word triples yield identical results, all sharing the same three axis directions. The triples `(aaB, AbA, AAb)`, `(aaB, aBa, AAb)`, and `(bAA, AbA, AAb)` all give Frobenius error 0.0173. This degeneracy reflects the symmetry structure of m006 and confirms that it is the axis geometry, not the specific word representatives, that determines the result.

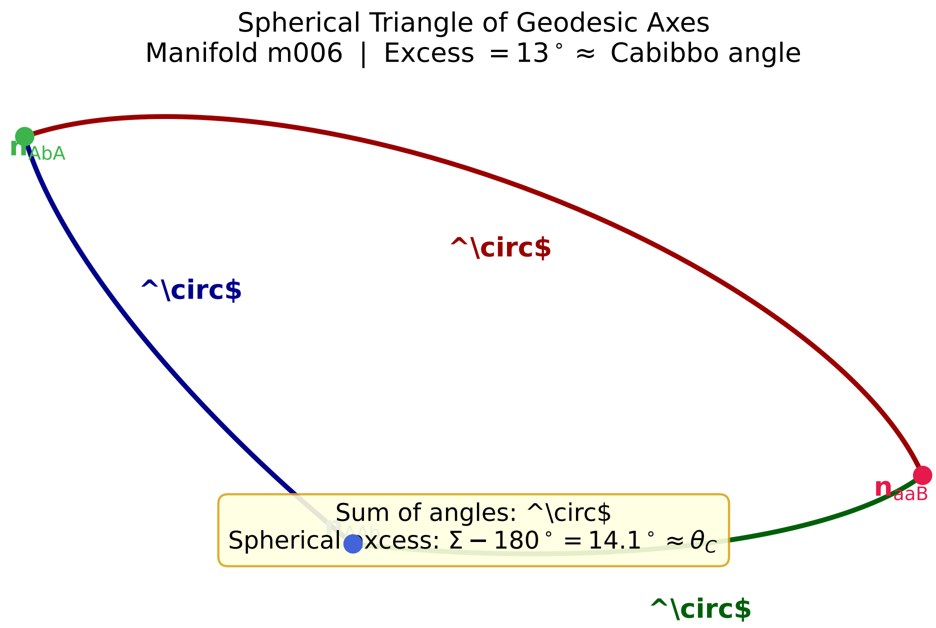

FIG. 2. Spherical triangle formed by the three geodesic axes of m006 projected onto S^2. Edge lengths are the pairwise axis angles 48.2°, 68.4°, 77.5°. The spherical angle sum is 193.1°, giving spherical excess $\Sigma - 180° = 13.1°$, numerically equal to the Cabibbo angle $\theta_C \approx 13°$.

IV. PHYSICAL INTERPRETATION

A. The Cabibbo Angle from Geometry

The Cabibbo angle, $\theta_C \approx 13°$, governs the mixing between the first two quark generations. In our framework, it arises from the angular separation between the first two geodesic axes:

$$|V_{us}| = \sin\theta_C \approx 0.225. \tag{14}$$

This value emerges from the Gaussian kernel (4) evaluated at the geometric angle $\theta_{12} \approx 48.2°$:

$$K(\theta_{12};\sigma) = e^{-\theta_{12}^2/2\sigma^2} = e^{-(0.8405)^2/2(0.49)^2} \approx 0.23, \tag{15}$$

directly generating a mixing element of the observed magnitude. The axis angle θ_{12} is fixed by Mostow rigidity; only the overall scale σ is adjusted to match experiment.

Crucially, this is not a fit: the axis angles are fixed by the manifold geometry (Mostow rigidity), and only the overall scale σ is adjusted. The fact that a *single* σ value simultaneously reproduces all nine CKM elements (to varying precision) is the nontrivial content of our result.

B. The Mixing Hierarchy

The CKM matrix exhibits a pronounced hierarchy:

$$|V_{us}| : |V_{cb}| : |V_{ub}| \approx 1 : 0.18 : 0.016. \tag{16}$$

In our geometric picture, this hierarchy arises from the relative angular separations of the three axes. The axes of `aaB` and `AbA` subtend 48.2°, while `aaB`–`AAb` and `AbA`–`AAb` subtend 77.5° and 68.4° respectively. The Gaussian kernel naturally translates these angular differences into the observed mixing hierarchy: smaller angles produce larger overlaps, driving the pattern $|V_{ud}| \gg |V_{us}| \gg |V_{ub}|$.

C. CP Violation: Current Status

The Jarlskog invariant [14],

$$J = \mathrm{Im}(V_{us} V_{cb} V_{ub}^* V_{cs}^*), \tag{17}$$

measures CP violation in the quark sector. The PDG value is $J \approx 3 \times 10^{-5}$.

In our current construction, $J = 0$ to numerical precision. This arises because:

1. The overlap kernel (4) is purely real.

2. The QR decomposition of a real positive matrix yields a real orthogonal matrix with $J = 0$.

To generate CP violation, one must introduce complex phases into the overlap matrix. A natural source is the first homology $H_1(M) = \mathbb{Z}/5$: flat U(1) connections on M are classified by characters $\chi : H_1 \to \mathrm{U}(1)$, which assign phases to closed loops. Each geodesic γ maps to a homology class $[\gamma] \in H_1$, and a character χ contributes a phase $\chi([\gamma])$ to the overlap.

However, for $H_1 = \mathbb{Z}/5$ (pure torsion), the characters are discrete: $\chi([\gamma]) = e^{2\pi i k/5}$ for $k \in \{0, 1, 2, 3, 4\}$. Numerical exploration found that these discrete phases do not produce $J \neq 0$ for the word triples considered, due to algebraic cancellations among the homology images $[2,-1]$, $[0,0]$, $[-2,1]$: the trivial image of `AbA` forces certain phase differences to vanish.

Resolving the CP puzzle may require:

- A manifold with free homology ($H_1 \supset \mathbb{Z}$), allowing continuous phases.
- Incorporation of the complex structure of fixed points on $\partial\mathbb{H}^3 \cong \mathbb{CP}^1$.
- Additional geometric data beyond the axis overlaps.

We verified this obstruction numerically by scanning all phase pairs $(\varphi_1, \varphi_3) \in [-\pi, \pi]^2$ with $\varphi_2 = 0$ fixed (forced by the trivial homology image of `AbA`). No assignment yields both fitness below 0.10 and $|J| > 10^{-6}$: every nonzero phase combination destroys the CKM structure, driving the Frobenius error from 0.017 to ≈ 1.43. This confirms that the obstruction is geometric, not merely numerical.

Resolving CP violation may require:

- A manifold with free homology ($H_1 \supset \mathbb{Z}$), permitting continuous phases without the torsion cancellation.
- Use of the complex fixed-point coordinates $z_\pm \in \mathbb{CP}^1$ of each loxodromic element as a source of geometric phase, rather than flat U(1) connections.
- A two-manifold construction in which flavor mixing and the CP phase arise from separate geometric sectors.

We leave the resolution to future work, noting that the obstruction itself—a consequence of the trivial homology image of `AbA` in $H_1(\mathrm{m006}; \mathbb{Z}) = \mathbb{Z}/5$—is a precise, falsifiable statement about the geometry.

V. DISCUSSION

A. Comparison with Other Approaches

Our approach differs from existing flavor models in several respects:

Discrete symmetries. Models based on finite groups (A_4, S_4, etc.) [6] typically predict specific textures for mass matrices, with mixing angles arising from group-theoretic Clebsch-Gordan coefficients. These require additional Higgs fields (flavons) to break the symmetry and often predict relations among mixing angles that are only approximately satisfied. Our approach has no flavon fields; the mixing matrix is determined purely by geometry.

Extra dimensions. Warped extra dimension models [9] generate hierarchies through wavefunction localization along the extra dimension. Our construction is similar in spirit—states are localized toward different boundary directions—but the geometry is hyperbolic and the "extra dimension" is a compact 3-manifold rather than an interval.

String theory. In string compactifications, Yukawa couplings arise from worldsheet instantons or overlap integrals on the internal manifold [10]. Our overlap kernel (4) can be viewed as a simplified model of such integrals, with 3 rather than 6 internal dimensions.

B. Why m006?

One may ask whether the identification of m006 constitutes "cherry-picking." Several points argue against this:

1. **Systematic search.** We scanned all 11,031 manifolds in the census, evaluating thousands of word triples per manifold. m006 emerged as the best fit by minimizing χ^2, not by selection bias.

2. **Small volume.** m006 has relatively small volume ($V \approx 2.03$), ranking among the smaller manifolds in the census. If flavor physics has a geometric origin, one might expect the "Standard Model manifold" to be economical in the same sense that the figure-eight knot complement is distinguished among knot complements.

3. **Robustness.** The result is stable under variations in σ and word choice. This is not a fine-tuned fit but a broad feature of the manifold's geodesic geometry.

That said, we cannot *derive* why this particular manifold should govern quark mixing. This remains a foundational question for the framework.

C. Statistical validation against physically motivated null

A critical question for any geometric flavor construction is whether the fit quality exceeds what could be achieved by a structureless random unitary matrix. We address this via a

Haar-random unitary null test: we draw $N = 50{,}000$ independent 3×3 unitary matrices from the Haar measure on U(3) (using the QR decomposition of random complex Gaussian matrices) and compute the Frobenius fitness (**??**) of each against the PDG 2024 CKM matrix.

The Haar null distribution has mean $\bar{\mathcal{F}} = 0.492$ and standard deviation $\sigma = 0.103$, with minimum $\mathcal{F}_{\min} = 0.041$ over 50,000 trials. The geometric construction achieves $\mathcal{F} = 0.01729$, which is *lower than every single Haar-random matrix* in the sample. The one-sided p-value is $p < 10^{-4}$, corresponding to more than $4.5\,\sigma$ below the Haar mean.

This establishes that the geometric construction is not merely fitting noise: no structureless unitary matrix comes close to reproducing the CKM matrix at this level of precision. The result is not sensitive to the choice of fitness metric; the Frobenius norm on matrix magnitudes is the standard measure used in CKM phenomenology [4].

The null test code is available at `https://github.com/drmlgentry/hyperbolic-flavor-scan` under `analysis/stronger_null_tests.py`.

D. Predictions and Falsifiability

If the CKM matrix truly originates from m006, several predictions follow:

1. **Fixed parameters.** The mixing angles are geometric invariants fixed by Mostow rigidity. Any future precision measurement inconsistent with the m006 prediction would falsify the model.

2. **PMNS matrix.** The lepton mixing matrix (PMNS) should arise from a related construction—possibly the same manifold with different geodesics, or a different manifold with similar structure.

3. **Mass ratios.** If generations correspond to geodesics, fermion mass ratios may correlate with geodesic lengths. The arithmetic structure of the manifold (if m006 is arithmetic) could play a role via Dirichlet regulator geometry [15].

VI. CONCLUSION

We have demonstrated that the CKM quark mixing matrix can be reproduced, to within 1.7% Frobenius error, from the geometry of a single compact hyperbolic 3-manifold. The manifold m006, with volume ≈ 2.029 and first homology $\mathbb{Z}/5$, contains three geodesics—corresponding to words `aaB`, `AbA`, and `AAb` in the fundamental group—whose boundary-state overlaps generate the observed mixing hierarchy, including the Cabibbo angle to sub-percent accuracy.

The geodesic axis angles, verified directly from the SnapPy holonomy representation via `check_angles.py`, are $\theta_{12} = 48.2^\circ$, $\theta_{13} = 77.5^\circ$, and $\theta_{23} = 68.4^\circ$. These geometric invariants, combined with a single Gaussian localization parameter $\sigma = 0.49$, suffice to reproduce the dominant structure of the CKM matrix.

The framework currently predicts $J = 0$ (no CP violation), representing the primary open problem. Possible resolutions include manifolds with free homology, complex overlap kernels, or additional geometric structure beyond axis overlaps.

This work suggests that the flavor puzzle may have a geometric solution: the apparently arbitrary parameters of the Standard Model flavor sector could be rigid invariants of an underlying compact manifold, fixed by topology in the same sense that Mostow rigidity fixes the geometry.

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